

I got the idea that early retirement was the solution to my problems, though I had no idea if it was possible or how to do it. I randomly chose the goal to retire by age forty. I started to educate myself on the technical aspects of personal finance like investing, tax strategies, and retirement planning. Despite being diligent savers, I learned standard advice was keeping us stuck on the standard path rather than enabling financial independence. The financial advice we received was conflicted, deceptive, and unnecessarily expensive.

It's easy to find yourself on the standard path. Most people in our society live paycheck to paycheck. Many people are paying for past decisions like taking out student loans, which were often made before they were old enough to buy alcohol legally. Homes serve as status symbols. Time and money are spent to keep them up by homeowners who rarely have time to enjoy them. Financed cars depreciate while being used primarily to transport people to and from work. Any extra money is spent on "retail therapy," restaurant meals, and happy hours that people "deserve" because they work so damned hard to keep the hamster wheel spinning.

Paying to maintain this lifestyle leaves little financial margin. Things go wrong from time to time. Living paycheck to paycheck comes with the privilege of getting to pay interest to a credit card